

The Gestalt Approach to Coaching

Peter Bluckert

INTRODUCTION

While practitioners from a clinical background will be familiar with Gestalt from the therapeutic arena (Gestalt therapy), what may be less well known is the increasingly coherent body of theory and practice relating to applications of Gestalt at the organizational level.

This chapter describes the key aspects of the Gestalt theoretical tradition and then sets out an emerging conceptual and methodological framework for a Gestalt coaching approach.

The theoretical tradition

Gestalt coaching finds its theory and practice from three places: Gestalt therapy and Gestalt psychology where the primary focus has been on individuals; and more recent applications of Gestalt to wider systems such as couples, families, teams and organizations.

It should be noted that Gestalt therapy is not simply a direct extension of Gestalt psychology. The pioneers of Gestalt therapy absorbed several philosophical and psychological traditions. The period from the 1950s to the 1980s, and particularly the earlier years when much of the influential work was done, was for many a time of deep questioning and dissatisfaction with the status quo. There was a fervent desire for change and an optimistic belief that it could happen. Those early founders, such as Fritz and Laura Perls and Paul Goodman, confronted the Freudian-based psychoanalytical establishment and embraced the radicalism of the time.

They sought their influences not only from psychoanalysis and Gestalt psychology but also from field theory, existential philosophy and the humanistic therapy movement of the time. In 1951, Perls, in collaboration with Goodman and Hefferline, published the seminal Gestalt text: *Gestalt Therapy: Excitement and Growth in the Human Personality*, ‘the cornerstone of the Gestalt approach’ (Latner, 1992: 15).

Gestalt psychology dates back to the early twentieth century and was developed in Germany by Max Wertheimer, Wolfgang Köhler and Kurt Koffka who were interested in the nature and structure of perceptual experience. They challenged the belief that there is an ‘objective reality’ and instead sought to understand how we make sense of our experience, moment by moment, against the background of the field which includes our current mental models and historical experience. They believed that people actively strive to impose order and meaningful wholes on what they see and experience. Indeed, the German word Gestalt, which does not easily translate into English, most approximates to words like pattern, shape, configuration, or meaningful organized whole.

From field theorists such as Kurt Lewin the concept of interconnectedness was adopted – that people exist as part of an environmental field, and behaviour can only be understood in relation to that field. An important implication here for organizational consultants, facilitators and coaches is that *you* cannot be outside of the field. The notion of the neutral, independent practitioner exerting no influence or impact on the system you are working with is rejected in the field perspective. The intervener may not be a member of the group, team or system but as Perls, Hefferline, and Goodman (1951: xi) said, ‘the whole determines the parts’; if you are part of the field it impacts you and you impact it.

The existential philosophy roots come from Kierkegaard, Sartre and Heidegger with their themes of personal responsibility, freedom and authenticity. In relational terms Buber’s philosophy of dialogue based on I–Thou connection, taken later into the therapeutic relationship as the dialogical method, was also influential. Phenomenology, which grew out of existentialism, advocates the value of staying as closely as possible to actual, raw, here-and-now data, rather than interpreting or judging it. In fact, Perls called Gestalt the ‘psychology of the obvious’.

Description, says Clarkson (2004: 4), is more important than interpretation. What this looks like in practice is an emphasis on descriptive rather than evaluative feedback and a more faithful reflection and honouring of the coachees’ own words, meanings and subjective experience. It calls on the coach to be observant of the body language and energetic presence of their client, fully attend to emotional needs as they arise and be aware of the contact issues within the relationship. Intrinsic in this approach is that the coach needs to focus on his/her own subjective experience and share this appropriately as part of an authentic dialogue. This sharing of the coach’s interior and exterior world in the service of the client is known as *the use of self*.

The Gestalt perspective of human functioning

Gestalt is a needs-based approach to understanding human functioning and behaviour. Through effective self-regulation people gratify needs and eliminate tensions. At the physical level this

is self evident. As a need, such as hunger emerges, it becomes an increasingly dominant *figure* against the background (*ground*) of that person's other experience. This produces a state of temporary imbalance until that need is met, when it then dissipates with a consequent withdrawal of interest and energy. This process was first described in Goldstein's (Hall & Lindzey, 1957) research where he offered the concept of *organismic self-regulation*. According to Goldstein there is a biological law of balance inherent in human nature and we are programmed to move towards the best form possible to find that balance.

Melnick and Nevis (2005) acknowledge the contribution that Goldstein's work made to our understanding of self-regulation as primarily a physiological process focusing on self preservation, but differentiate it from another important Gestalt concept, *creative adjustment*. This is the notion that we are always seeking to do the best we can in any given circumstances to meet our needs, find solutions to our problems, achieve our goals, and derive satisfaction from our lives. Through creative adjustment Melnick and Nevis (2005: 22) suggest that 'change can happen quickly and permanently'.

Gestalt applications to organizations

The earliest applications of Gestalt within the organizational context are ascribed to Wallen and Nevis. Beginning in 1959, they used awareness-raising techniques within sensitivity training groups for managers. This work can be seen as a forerunner of today's workshop-based emotional intelligence programmes.

Nevis went on to play a leading role in the application of Gestalt principles to management and organizational development, setting up the Organization Development Center at the Gestalt Institute of Cleveland in the USA, along with Carter, Lukensmeyer, Hannafin and Siminovitch, and writing the seminal text on the subject, *Organizational Consulting: A Gestalt Approach* (1987). Elsewhere and throughout the world there have been a growing number of Gestalt organizational practitioners who have taken their own Gestalt styles into process consultancy, team development, mediation and one-to-one consultation. In recent years, some of these have rebranded their one-to-one work as executive coaching.

My own applications of Gestalt to organizational consultancy began in the early 1980s through leadership and personal development programmes and since then it has been my primary psychological frame of reference for team development, executive coaching and the training and development of coaches and OD consultants (Bluckert, 2006).

MAIN ASSUMPTIONS AND BELIEFS

Underpinning all Gestalt-based work is the following set of core assumptions and beliefs:

- Gestalt practitioners believe that *people are always doing the best they can*. (Melnick & Nevis, 2005: 13). This belief emanates from the Gestalt perspective of resistance as a meaningful and healthy act when understood from

the position of the so-called resistor. Indeed, the Gestalt concept of *creative adjustment* is founded in the belief that people make the best decisions and alter behaviour towards the best outcomes available *within* the external constraints and their own perceptions of what is possible at that time. With this in mind Gestalt can be seen as a positive psychology.

- The Gestalt theory of change, the *paradoxical theory of change* (Beisser, 1970), states that change occurs when one is fully in contact with 'what is', the truth of our experience, rather than trying to be different or disowning parts of ourselves. We must become our truth first before we can move from it. In translating this for the coach, Siminovitch and Van Eron (2006: 52) say, 'A fundamental intervention in Gestalt coaching is to sharply focus attention on what already exists for the client in the present, with the paradoxical result of initiating a profound experiential shift towards something new'. As a consequence of this theoretical perspective the skills and methods are used to support the client to get in contact and stay in contact with 'what is'. *Contact*, a core construct in Gestalt, is defined by Stevenson (2004: 5) as 'the psychological process whereby I allow myself to meet my self (as in memories and imagination); to meet a person, group, or organization; or to meet the environment: a sunset ... and I can most effectively make such contact by staying present-centred'.
- A fundamental premise of all Gestalt-based work is that through heightened *awareness* people can more readily organize themselves into new ways of seeing, choosing and acting. Out of this awareness we energize ourselves and take actions that lead to the achievement of important goals. In completing these cycles we assimilate learning as well as gain closure around issues. Implicit in this assumption is that our actions may not lead to our desired results and therefore we may not attain our goals if they are based on impoverished awareness.
- Individual behaviour cannot be fully understood without reference to its context. Each context and situation contains its own dynamic, requiring the coach to appreciate systems and levels beyond the individual. This is known as the *field perspective*.
- The power of *unfinished business* not only drains energy, focus and motivation but also holds us back from fulfilling our potential and seeking out the new possibilities existing in our current situation. Worse still, our unfinished situations may block us from even opening ourselves to the awareness of those possibilities.
- The exploration of here and now, immediate experience, provides opportunities for learning and growth. This accounts for the classic Gestalt question, 'What are you aware of now?'.

THE DEFINING FEATURES OF A GESTALT APPROACH

As Saner (1999: 6) puts it 'one of the distinguishing features of Gestalt is its emphasis on the role that awareness plays in achieving effective behaviour and a healthy way of life'. Gestalt focuses on the individual's (or system's) experience in the present moment, the environmental context or 'field' in which this takes place and the self-regulating adjustments people make as a result of the overall situation. The Gestalt coach is interested in how their client meets or fails to meet their needs and assists them to better understand their own process, especially their habitual thinking and behavioural patterns. This emphasis on awareness as the change agent means that the Gestalt coach needs to learn to be an 'awareness expert'.

Carter (2004) identifies practitioner identity and the effective use of self as the key determinants of the master practitioner. To this I would add the capacity to use the Cycle of Experience (Figure 5.1) as the orienting framework for appreciation of process issues and as the basis for intervention decisions.

For the coachee to experience the support they require for deeper, reflective work, the coach also needs the capacity to build trust, respect and connection. It is generally acknowledged that

Table 5.1: A framework for Gestalt coaching practice

<i>Defining features</i>	<i>Guiding theoretical perspectives</i>
A. A focus on <i>the need-fulfilment process</i> – how we satisfy (or not) needs, achieve closure around issues, assimilate learning and achieve desired goals	• The Cycle of Experience • Interruptions to contact
B. A focus on <i>how to use self</i>	• Presence and the intentional use of self as instrument of change
C. A focus on <i>the coaching relationship</i>	• Authentic dialogue

the nature and quality of the coaching relationship is a critical factor in successful coaching outcomes.

With these notions in mind I now offer a framework for Gestalt coaching practice, whether or not this is practised in the organizational context (Table 5.1).

A. The need-fulfilment process

The cycle of experience as the orienting framework

The Cycle of Experience is the Gestalt model for understanding how we satisfy (or not) our needs and achieve closure around issues. It is the primary orienting framework for a Gestalt-oriented coach providing a reference point for tracking what Siminovitch and Van Eron (2006: 53) call ‘the natural and ongoing experiential processes of need-fulfilment at any level of system’. It equally helps the coach identify when and where people and systems may be stuck, providing clues as to where and how to intervene. The Cycle of Experience is typically represented as a staged process (Figure 5.1), beginning with sensation, moving through awareness and energy mobilization to action and contact, producing resolution, closure and withdrawal of interest.

For the most part people complete Cycles of Experience in an easy, uncomplicated way, especially when it comes to meeting their physical needs. I qualify this with the words ‘for the most part’ because even at the physical level we do not always engage in a healthy flow. Sometimes, for very good reasons, we go without sufficient food, sleep, exercise or relaxation. We cut corners with ourselves.

Self evidently the process can be far more complex at the social, emotional and spiritual levels. A very common emotional ‘figure’ in the workplace is the issue of inclusion, yet many people go through prolonged periods of feeling devalued, ignored or sidelined by a boss or the organization. When this happens their energy can be stuck on a negative focus and lead to self-defeating activity. This is what is known as an unfinished situation or ‘unfinished business’.

Interruptions to contact So, what gets in the way of completing cycles? The following *interruptions to contact* are sometimes presented as forms of unconscious resistance but may be more usefully understood as aspects of creative adjustment. From this perspective there

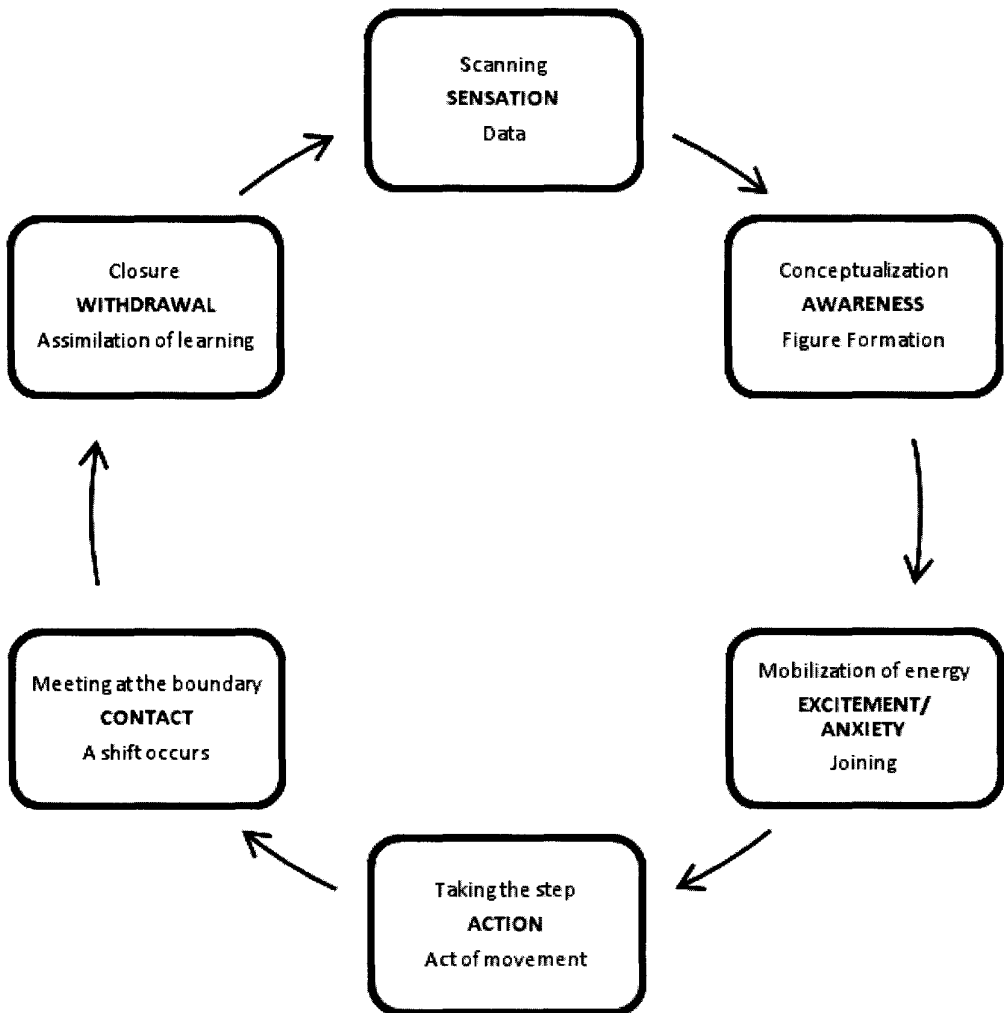


Figure 5.1 Cycle of Experience as orienting framework.

Source: Adapted from Siminovitch and Van Eron (2006).

is a positive dimension although they can also limit our capacity to make strong, lasting and authentic contact.

Gestalt theory identifies four major interruptions to contact – *introjection*, *retrofection*, *projection* and *confluence*. Presented as a list they could be seen as separate psychological processes, yet they connect and interrelate in complex and important ways, particularly introjection and retrofection, which have marked relevance for the coach.

Introjection refers to the process of ‘swallowing’ whole the beliefs, attitudes, values and edicts of significant others. This especially happens in early life and many of these introjections are useful, even necessary. When parents tell their children not to put their fingers into an electrical power socket they want this to be introjected. At the societal level, there are countless norms which nations need their citizens to introject to hold it together – driving on the correct side of the road being a simple example. Companies seek to instil certain values and behaviours in their staff which they want to be introjected without too much argument. Customer service is an example of this; working to the leadership agenda is another.

The negative consequences of introjection occur when internalized ‘shoulds’ and ‘should-nots’, ‘oughts’ and ‘ought-nots’ prevent people from being able to seek and achieve satisfaction of important personal needs. The young girl who grows up with the message ‘put others first’, may struggle to assert her own needs in adult life. She may hardly allow herself to recognize her own needs. When asked by her coach, ‘What is it you want from your life?’ or ‘Where do you want your career to go?’ this woman is likely to look perplexed and reply ‘I really don’t know. I don’t often think about those kinds of things’.

A far-reaching implication of introjection is that we can never fully know how much, or little, of what we think and believe about the world is undigested material from our pasts – a recycling of other people’s views, opinions and mental frameworks.

From this perspective the developmental aspect of coaching is about the coachee discovering what they think and believe, what they want from their work and wider life, and who they really are and want to be. As they proceed on their journey they will probably decide to hold on to much of what they introjected, but from the knowledge that they have taken it out, examined it and made it their own. They may equally cast off or re-evaluate some previously held truths.

Retroreflection means to turn inward upon oneself. We retroreflect when we believe it would be unwise, even dangerous, to speak or act out what we inwardly wish to say or do. We perceive that there is simply too little support and safety to do otherwise. In the workplace people retroreflect to protect their careers or for political reasons on such a regular basis that it can become a habit, a behavioural norm.

Working in the organizational context coaches are confronted with examples of retroreflection on a regular basis. Whether their work is with individuals, training groups, teams, departments or the entire system they cannot avoid retroreflection. Bottling up of unexpressed views and feelings may simply be part of the human condition and may be the best we can come up with in many situations. We may wish to avoid hurting the other person, it may just be a bad time, or the individual is simply unavailable to deal with directly. Retroreflection of different or challenging views may be the wisest course of action when there is a real question of what is safe to share in a given context.

However, there are consequences of habitual retroreflection. Turning inward what perhaps needs to be expressed outwardly can have serious effects on our health and well-being and diminish the quality of relationships. Instead of being easy and comfortable in the other

person's company we either minimize contact, because it's too difficult, or stay in superficial connection.

While retrofection clearly impacts at the individual and relationship level it can also have a critical impact on organizational performance. Individual team members are often caught up in a culture of retrofection where people go through the motions of teamwork and collaboration but at a deeper, more significant level keep their real thoughts, opinions and feelings to themselves. They also withhold their energy and commitment and some never fully join the enterprise of which they are part. Given these dynamics it is vital that coaches operating in corporate environments understand the nature of organizational relationships if they are to intervene effectively.

B. How to use self

Presence and the intentional use of self as instrument of change

From a Gestalt perspective coaches inevitably bring their presence into the coaching situation. The more relevant questions are about how well they understand their presence and what it evokes in others, to what extent it is grounded and integrated, and whether the coach can bring flexibility and intentionality to it.

Presence is not the same as charisma or style which can certainly be aspects of presence but only go part of the way towards capturing it. Our presence emanates from our ways of being and acting in the world. It contributes to whether we attract and interest others; it can also be a critical factor in distancing them or putting them off. It is the source of the coach's capacity to influence and equally it can explain lack of impact. For example the coach may not be filling their place and space in a room, perhaps coming through too timidly. This may be due to shutting parts of themselves off from a belief that they don't belong in that arena. The result can be a severe loss of power and the coach may look back with disappointment and regret that they didn't establish their presence sufficiently strongly to have impact.

Siminovitch and Van Eron (2006: 51) unpack the notion of presence and practitioner identity in the following way: *life experiences; an intellectual repertoire; particular skills or strengths as well as weaknesses or vulnerabilities; spiritual values and beliefs; and physical presence itself*. Presented in this way it is clear that everyone brings their presence whether or not they are seen by others as charismatic.

From a practitioner perspective we now need to return to the issue of how much we know about our presence and how to use it in the service of the coachee. As argued elsewhere (Bluckert, 2006: 107), this emphasises the critical importance of self development in the journey towards coaching excellence. The coach with less developed awareness won't always understand their impact and may need to learn how to use different aspects of self – soft and hard, loud and quiet, strong and mild – to become a more finely tuned instrument of change. One of the best ways coaches can gain that deeper appreciation of their presence is through an active process of seeking feedback from the widest range of sources – colleagues, clients, trainers

and fellow workshop participants on development programmes. As the coach begins to understand their presence they can develop more assurance and creativity in their interventions.

The nature of those interventions will depend on what the coach believes will be most valuable at the time. The Cycle of Experience, the key orienting model of the Gestalt coach, indicates that much of the early work which establishes the safe foundations for developmental work lies at the awareness raising stage. Learning the art of raising awareness is therefore a core competency.

In setting out his main activities of a Gestalt practitioner, Nevis (1987: 57) offers two important pointers to working at the awareness stage of the Cycle:

- Attend, observe and selectively share observations of what you see, hear and feel.
- Attend to your own experience (feelings, sensations, thoughts, etc.) and selectively share these, thereby establishing your presence in doing so.

These direct the coach to what they are noticing in their coachee or client system, in themselves, and the relationship between. The term ‘selectively share’ is important here and is where the finer art of coaching applies. Well-timed, skilful articulation of observations is the stock-in-trade of the highly accomplished coach. Clumsy, ill-timed interventions can risk the safety, trust and confidence so vital to the working alliance.

Bringing intentionality to coaching interventions also has a tactical dimension. In the early stages of a coaching relationship the presence which most lends itself to awareness raising can be evocative in nature – one which is softer, quieter, milder and leaning towards support. On some occasions and with some coachees this approach may not always be enough or what is valued. A more provocative presence may be necessary. It can be important in these circumstances to alter one’s energetic presence in order to match the different energy of the coachee.

C. The coaching relationship

Authentic dialogue

We shouldn’t underestimate the importance of the coach–coachee relationship in determining coaching outcomes. The relationship is the vehicle through which the coachee stretches and challenges themselves, goes to their learning edge and, with support, stays there long enough to deepen awareness and learn something. The importance of establishing and maintaining a contactful, trusting connection makes it one of the primary challenges for any coach.

From a Gestalt perspective the responsibility for building this lies with both parties and the nature of the connection has certain defining features. The Gestalt coach is asked to put themselves into the relationship and be fully present with all that this means in terms of not only their strengths and skills but also their flaws and vulnerabilities. The Gestalt coaching presence requires what Yontef (2002: 18) describes as ‘*authenticity, transparency, and humility*’.

Starting from this position the Gestalt coach strives to develop a particular quality of interaction grounded in inclusion, collaborative partnership, strong contact and a commitment to dialogue. The coach is encouraged to learn the messages from relational Gestalt therapy, and from relational therapy in general, of the importance of compassion, kindness, empathy and humility. The Gestalt coach works as much from their heart as from their head and gut.

However, this emphasis on supportive, empathic behaviours doesn't simply mean 'being nice'. There is a time when the most supportive thing a coach can do is to bring a tough, challenging presence. Coachees can be complex, confusing, frustrating, irritating and downright ingenuous. Sometimes they will criticize and blame the coach when the responsibility for the issue lies primarily with them. There will be occasions when it seems impossible to reach and make connection with the coachee. These are the times when the coach's commitment to 'unconditional positive regard' will be most severely tested. The clue here is in the word authenticity; to be authentic requires honesty. When the coach steps too far back from that he/she will not be fully present or available to engage in genuine dialogue.

Implicit in the Gestalt relational approach is the notion that the coach as well as the coachee will be potentially changed by the work undertaken together. The coach should expect to be moved and impacted by the process. The coachees' story, their struggles, their joys and their pain will touch you and remind you of your own. The very nature of the dialogue requires this openness to meeting at the boundary, where the coachee may never have been before, especially in the professional environment.

Dialogue moves beyond discussion when what Buber referred to as the I-It relationship is transformed into I-Thou connecting. When we are related to as an 'It' we feel like an object. The coachee could be talking to anyone. When we are related to as 'Thou' we experience our personhood. The contact becomes more real, immediate and interesting.

The challenge then for the Gestalt coach is to get into contact with their coachee, work with the emerging process, and let go of the need for certainty and control. This involves what Yontef (2002: 18) calls 'surrendering to the between', that which is co-created by both coach and coachee. Allan and Whybrow (2007: 136) describe how the

attention to the relationship and the spirit of enquiry means that something new can emerge that was not in the minds of either party when the dialogue started. It is in this potentially very creative way that something completely appropriate for the current situation is generated.

It is here that we capture the essence of Gestalt: that the *whole can be greater than the sum of the parts*.

If the coach is genuinely engaged in the experience there will be learning and growth available for them also. If the coach stays firmly in control and is unable to surrender to the 'in-between' then opportunities for learning will be missed and the message to the coachee is that coaching is a one-way learning process. For sure, many senior executives will not respond well to this.

The implications of the Gestalt relational approach may present as intriguing and exciting with the possibility of a high level of practitioner satisfaction. That much is undoubtedly true but the approach can look equally daunting. To be appropriately transparent to others and

present oneself in a genuine manner requires a good deal of personal courage as well as comfort in one's own skin. It may seem far easier and safer to adopt a quasi 'doctor–patient' relationship and hide behind the protection of the expert role.

This traditional 'helper–helped' model will also be nearer to what many coachees expect from their coaching engagement, at least in the first instance. Coachees often assume that the coach will take charge and provide the direction for the coaching. The Gestalt approach can therefore seem at odds with their expectations.

All this probably points to the best-fit coaching clients for a Gestalt approach. They are likely to be relational and reflective by nature with a healthy interest in their interior as well as exterior worlds, have a strong sense of their inner authority and not be overly needy of structure and certainty.

APPLICATIONS OF GESTALT COACHING

In a very real sense Gestalt principles and methods underpin all coaching and mentoring practice whether delivered by externals or internals in organizations, conducted with teams or individuals, designed to address performance or developmental agendas, or offered in the wider life context. This is because *all good coaching and mentoring is based on raising awareness as the starting point for learning and change*. In that sense any and every coach can benefit from a certain amount of Gestalt training and Gestalt-based coaching can be used in all coaching contexts.

That said, there are reasons why some contexts will be more appropriate than others. The manager as coach, being asked by his/her company to adopt more of a coaching style of management, will at best receive no more than a short training in coaching skills, usually two to five days in duration. It will probably focus around a model such as GROW and involve a limited amount of practice. The internalizing of a Gestalt informed conceptual and methodological framework in such a short developmental timeframe is unrealistic and is therefore rarely used in this context. We should not fail to notice however that the R in GROW stands for Reality and is the equivalent to the 'What is' in Gestalt. The Gestalt contribution to coaches using the GROW model would be to raise awareness more fully before rushing to Options.

The best-fit contexts for a Gestalt coaching approach are *executive/leadership coaching, developmental coaching, team coaching and life coaching*. Coaches operating in these contexts often bring previous relevant training and development, which prepares them for working in this way. A significant proportion of executive coaches and some life coaches come from psychological, psychotherapeutic, or counselling backgrounds where they may have already undertaken a primary or secondary level of Gestalt education.

These four coaching contexts also tend to give the coach longer to work with their coachee or client system (team). This is important to the Gestalt coach because it provides the opportunity to more deeply understand the coachees' process, gain a better sense of their habitual

behavioural and ideational patterns, and explore how these serve them well and how they interfere with the achievement of their goals. This is equally true in the team context where suboptimal group dynamics, team norms and behaviours may be blocking high performance.

EVALUATION OF THE THEORY

The key strengths lie in the optimism, directness and power inherent in the Gestalt approach. Organizational life, indeed life in general, forces people to address an increasing level of complexity and chaos. Leaders and managers often experience prolonged periods of anxiety from living life in the executive fast lane. They have to dig deep into their capacity to self-support. This can challenge their capacity to stay optimistic, positive and healthy. They can get stuck in negative spirals for prolonged periods yet hardly appreciate the effect on their own well-being, let alone on their colleagues and close ones. The freeing up of that energy, releasing the person from being trapped in unfinished business or redundant ways of seeing and acting can be nothing short of liberating and life-enhancing.

To work in a Gestalt way the coach needs to adopt a positive, optimistic, supportive stance and offer what Siminovitch and Van Eron (2006: 51) call 'a safe arena where vulnerability, strong emotions and failure can play themselves out in the service of learning and growth'. Finding such a place for deeper reflection and self disclosure is rare for business leaders who typically believe that they must remain self-contained and on guard.

Nonetheless, the Gestalt method will be countercultural for some coachees. The deceptively simple yet immensely profound notion that awareness itself leads to change, and that change happens just by paying attention to 'what is' rarely forms part of a coachees' mental models. Executives may be sceptical of it and impatient to see proof. If they don't see it quickly they can lose interest and commitment. Some managers and leaders operating in fast-paced, numbers-driven business environments may not be the natural client group for Gestalt coaching. Awareness-focused work may seem just too slow for them. This type of client also tends to see results only in terms of tangible outcomes and benefits. If the session hasn't produced a concrete action plan then it may be dismissed as too esoteric or subtle.

In corporate life, executive coaches are often labelled in either of two ways by their clients – white coats or suits. Gestalt coaches with a strong therapeutic background but less consultancy experience can be in danger of confusing the boundaries between therapy and coaching. There are occasions in coaching when the coachees' presenting issues could suggest a therapeutic response. Well-trained and supervised coaches become aware that in these moments, despite any glaring therapeutic issues facing them, they need to resist the clinical invitation.

Though the Gestalt coach may sometimes need to step back from more intensive personal growth work, the Gestalt approach nevertheless offers great scope for satisfaction in the role. The emphasis on Presence and the Use of Self as Instrument invites the coach to bring themselves more fully to what they do. This is not a method that asks the coach to fit into a mould

or to learn a set of tools and techniques to operate on someone else. From a Gestalt perspective the coach is the instrument of change.

With this comes the hard and disciplined part. If coaches are going to intentionally use presence to intervene more effectively, then they have to understand more about who they are and what they bring to the coaching encounter. The critical issue here is the self-development work that this requires. While many coaches recognize this and proactively search out the kinds of places that provide a vehicle for their own learning and growth there are those who back off from the journey. The Gestalt approach may not appeal to them because they can see that it takes a long time, and perhaps some pain along the way, to gain mastery.

Gestalt theory is an eclectic mix of old and new concepts and beliefs. It draws on philosophy, psychology and humanistic psychotherapy to create a broad canvas onto which the practitioner can bring their own unique style and creativity. Because Gestalt is not formulaic or prescriptive the approach is always in a state of emergence as new generations make their own mark in response to the ever-changing field and the contexts in which they work.

What has been important to me about Gestalt is that its philosophical principles draw on deep wisdom that transcends time and speaks to a set of truths that I recognize for myself. In translating those into my own practice as a consultant and coach I find they speak also to others.

FURTHER READING

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